

The piano keyboard

To understand note names and octaves, it is helpful to look at a piano keyboard. The pattern of white keys and black keys explains a lot about how pitch is organized.

The piano keyboard

The distinctive pattern of black keys—grouped alternately in twos and threes—marks out the octaves. Each octave has seven white keys—A B C D E F G—and five black keys. A full-sized keyboard usually has around seven octaves. The central C on the keyboard is called Middle C, and this is a fixed point of reference, which is important when music is written down in notation.

SEE ALSO

◀ 14–15	High and low
Clefs	20–21 ▶
Sharps and flats	48–51 ▶
Keyboards	180–181 ▶

REAL WORLD

Grand piano

The piano is the most versatile of instruments, and many string, brass, and wind players like to learn it as a second instrument. Unlike most wind and string instruments, it can play several notes at the same time—for instance a melody plus chordal accompaniment.



The black keys occur in twos and threes. This pattern marks out the octaves, and enables us to locate the white keys.

1



△ The piano

With its unique layout, the piano is a useful instrument for learning music theory. The relationships between the notes, especially the white and black keys, is made clear.

The white key between the two black keys grouped in twos is always D. C is always the white key just below these two black keys.

2

The C nearest the middle of a full-size keyboard is called Middle C.